

DISGUISED FIREARMS

Since the 16th century, attempts have been made to disguise firearms as other objects (see pp. 222–23). Although early ignition systems (wheel-lock and flintlock) prevented any degree of effective disguise, the introduction of the self-contained metallic cartridge made it possible. As a result, from the mid-19th century onward, firearms have been made in the form of canes, umbrellas, pens, and so forth. These arms are effective only at close range, and civilian use of them is frowned upon by authorities because the weapons could be utilized for nefarious purposes, such as assassinations.



Trigger



Muzzle

Trigger

◀ CIGARETTE LIGHTER PISTOL

Date	1970s
Origin	Not known
Barrel	1½in (4cm)
Caliber	.22in

What appears to be a cigarette lighter actually contains a single-shot pistol. The trigger is of a clasp type and runs up the side of the “gun” body. It is not known which country produced this firearm, but it was made in the 1970s.



Flashlight casing conceals weapon mechanics

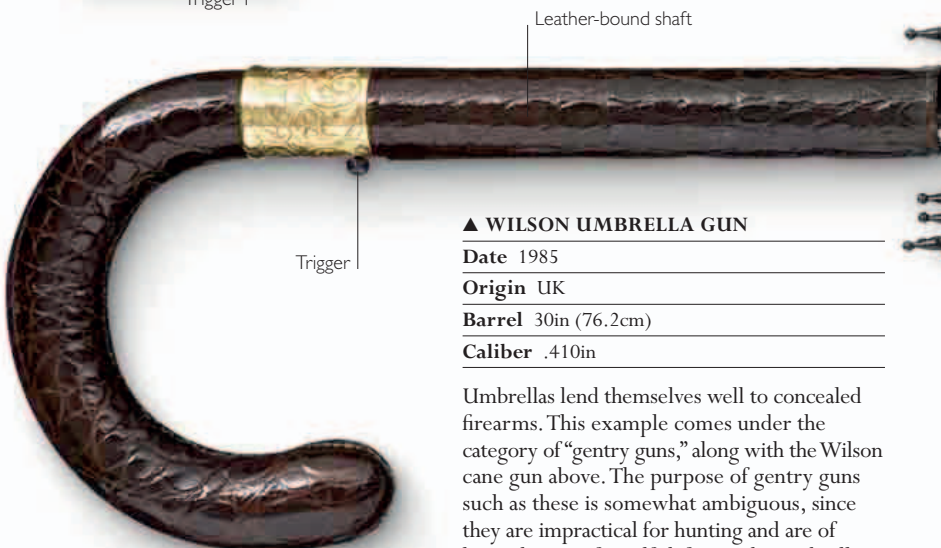
Trigger

Bullet fires through front of flashlight

▲ FLASHLIGHT STINGER

Date	1980s
Origin	US
Barrel	2in (5cm)
Caliber	.22in

This covert weapon is disguised as a flashlight and actually contains a .22in single-shot firearm. The bullet is loaded behind the flashlight’s bulb section and is fired by depressing the light switch.



Trigger

Leather-bound shaft

▲ WILSON UMBRELLA GUN

Date	1985
Origin	UK
Barrel	30in (76.2cm)
Caliber	.410in

Umbrellas lend themselves well to concealed firearms. This example comes under the category of “gentry guns,” along with the Wilson cane gun above. The purpose of gentry guns such as these is somewhat ambiguous, since they are impractical for hunting and are of limited power for self-defense. This umbrella gun has a center-fire mechanism around its barrel. However, it is not licensed for sporting use in the US.



Chamber